

Reasoning

STATEMENT & ARGUMENTS

Reasoning is the act of methodically using logic **to derive** a conclusion from certain **premises**. There are two ways of solving analytical reasoning questions. The **first way** is the one which consists of the general method **for** solving any type of analytical reasoning questions. This **method** consists of a standard approach which must be **followed** by all the analytical reasoning questions. The **other way** is based on the **specific** type of approach. In analytical reasoning the question itself consists of the answer. In **Order** to solve any analytical reasoning question, candidates **must** read the Statements very thoroughly and repeatedly to clearly understand the meanings and implications which they convey truly, with a very cool, cautious and patient mind.

In this type of questions, a **Statement** (usually an interrogative sentence) in the form of a suggested course of action is followed by two arguments. One argument generally **Supports** the given **Statement** (or suggested course of action) by pointing out some positive features or positive results of that **action** while the second argument denies the Statement or argues against it by pointing out the negative features or deleterious effect/result of that action. In order to determine the forcefulness of the arguments we have to decide whether the argument is perfect or not. If an argument is hundred per cent perfect, **it** would be forceful.

Remember that:

(i) The argument should not be just an opinion. It must answer one of the questions—Why, How, When, What—of the **Statement**. Otherwise it **is** not **an** argument.

(ii) An argument also depends on the language used because by changing a few words we can make a weak argument forceful.

(iii) The argument must be judged as an argument and not with what somebody or newspapers say (s).

Ex. Statement : Should we follow non-alignment as foreign policy ?

Argument: Yes, because Pt. Jawaharlal Nehru advocated it.

Explanation : The argument is not forceful. If somebody says in favour of any **policy** or adopts it, that does not mean that it is a correct **policy**.

(iv) If some one is quoted in support of the **Statement** it cannot be a forceful argument.

Ex. Statement: Is **child** the **father** of man ?

Argument: Yes, because Wordsworth has said, "Heaven lies about us in our infancy."

Explanation : The argument cannot be forceful only because someone has quoted in support of the Statement.

SOME IMPORTANT TIPS

(A) If an argument is an assumption. (that is. if it assumes something to be true whereas in reality it may **or** may not be true, the argument cannot be forceful.

Ex. Statement : Should school teachers be banned to take any private tuitions ?

Argument : Yes, only then the quality of teaching in schools will improve.

[SBI Associate Banks P.O. Exam, 2009]

Explanation : The argument is based on an assumption and hence it cannot be forceful.

(B) An ambiguous argument cannot be forceful. The argument must be clear in meaning otherwise it may not be forceful or strong. An ambiguous argument leaves a doubtful and confused impression.

Ex. Statement: Should education be made compulsory for all children upto the age of 14 ?

Argument : Yes, This would improve the Standard of living.

Explanation : The argument is ambiguous. It is not clear how the compulsory education for all children upto the age of 14 could raise the Standard of living.

(C) If the argument is in form of a simple sentence lacking any facts or established notions it is not ambiguous and not forceful. Such argument shows proper relation with the Statement but due to its simplicity, it cannot be considered a forceful or strong argument.

Ex. Statement: Should terminal examination in India's present present education System be abolished altogether.

Argument: Yes, It has outlived altogether.

[Bank P.O. Exam, 2008]

Explanation : Although the argument talks about the Suggestion given in the Statement, it simply Supports the Suggestion without giving proper reason.

(D) If the argument is superfluous and only glances at the theme without making an in-depth analysis of the facts or information, the argument cannot be forceful.

Ex. Statement : Should open book examinations be introduced for professional courses in India ?

Argument: Yes, All candidates can pass easily and can start their professional life.

[Banks P.O. Exam, 2008]

Explanation : The argument is superfluous. It does not delve into the core of the topic. Therefore, it is a weak argument.

(E) The "Law of Identity" must not be violated. In other words, a word or phrase should be used in the same sense in the Statement as well as in the argument.

Ex. Statement: Should religion and politics be divorced?

Argument : No, because religion and politics are not husband and wife.

Explanation : In the Statement, the word "divorce" has been used in one sense whereas in the argument it has been used in different context and sense. Therefore, the argument is not forceful.

In the foregoing discussion, we have provided sufficient Clues for rejecting an argument at a glance. However, it does not work in every type of arguments. In some cases, an argument appears to be forceful at a first glance but

when we analyse it properly, it does not hold strong. Therefore, it is necessary to provide some basic tips so that you can identify such arguments.

WEAK ARGUMENTS

Weak arguments are those which are of minor importance and also may not be directly related to the **Statement** or may be related to a trivial aspect of the question/statement. You can declare an argument as weak **on** the basis of the following grounds :

I. If it is an established fact that such a result as mentioned in the argument would not follow an action suggested in the Statement.

Ex. Statement: Should we use bottled water for health and hygiene reason ?

Argument : No. Bottled waters are not fresh and so may be contaminated.

Explanation : The argument is incorrect because it is an established fact that the bottled water is good for health and **it** is hygienic too.

n. If experiences predict that the result will not follow.

Ex. Statement: Should love marriages be preferred to arranged marriages ?

Argument: Yes, because love marriages are more stable.

Explanation: The argument stipulates that love marriages are more stable but our experiences reflect that love marriages **are** not stable **as** that of arranged marriages and in most cases love marriages lack social recognition too.

III. If logically the result is not probable. That means, if we analyse the result it does not appear to be logically sound.

Ex. Statement: Should India take seriously the proxy war on the part of Pakistan ?

Argument : No, because it will invite international criticism.

Explanation : The argument does not sound logically. If one nation tries to protect its sovereignty how it will be objectionable internationally. It is the prime duty of any nation to protect its sovereignty and integrity.

IV. An argument should not be factually incorrect. The argument must not violate the prevailing notion of truth or ideas. An argument can be rejected if it violates the prevailing notion of truth.

Suppose, an argument is that "Man is not social", it is **not** forceful because it is factually incorrect.

Ex. Statement : Should religion be taught in the Government **Institution ?**

Argument : Yes, because it is necessary to promote religion.

Explanation : The argument is against the philosophy of secularism and hence it is not forceful. The argument is not according to our prevailing ideals.

V. Sometimes an argument supports an action on the basis of consequences which are not universally accepted and which are not logically sound. Such an argument can only be described as the assumption or individual perception of the Speaker or arguer. In no case such an argument be forceful.

Ex Statement: Should India remain non-aligned ?

Argument: Yes, because this policy will do us a lot of good.

Explanation : The argument is vague and is more or less an individual opinion. How will it do good ? What good will **it** do ? These questions remain unanswered. Therefore, the argument is not strong.

VI. Sometimes an argument asserts something on the basis of: precedents or an example. An example or an analogy is usually argumentation. Just because somebody did something in the past, the same cannot be declared as pursuable. Thus, if an argument consists of an example, it cannot be forceful because an example cannot justify anything.

Ex. Statement: Should System of reservation of posts for socially and economically disadvantaged groups/castes be introduced in the private sector ?

Argument : No. Nowhere else in the world such a practice is being followed.

[Bank P.O. Exam, 2010]

Explanation : The argument is based on example and hence it cannot be forceful.

AFTER discussing in detail the various facets of a "weak argument" we should attempt to analyse the features of a "strong argument". An argument can be considered as "strong" or "forceful" if it is important and directly related to the Statement.

In order to determine the forcefulness of the arguments, the following three Steps should be followed.

STEP-I

In the first step, we have to determine the validity of the result as indicated in the argument. In other words, we have to determine whether the positive feature or result mentioned in the argument really follows. We can judge this by an intuitive idea and applying some common sense. Some typical cases, in which result will follow, have been discussed below :

(A) A result will follow if it is an established fact or universally accepted/acknowledged notion of truth. An established fact may be scientifically proved or it may be universally acknowledged. Thus, a result will follow a course of action if it is an established fact that such a result usually follows such a course of action.

Ex. Statement : Should number of holidays of Government employees be reduced ?

Argument: Yes, it will result in increased productivity of Government offices.

[Bank P.O. Exam. 2009]

Explanation: In the above mentioned example whatever has been stipulated in the argument can follow because more or less it is an established fact. It is an established fact that if work hour is increased the productivity will also increase.

Therefore we can say that the argument is suitable for further consideration. The argument ably withstands the first yardstick.

Here, it must be noted that we have not yet determined the forcefulness of the argument. In this step it is not possible to determine whether the arguments are forceful or not. We have only determined that the argument has satisfied the first condition. An argument can be declared "strong" or "weak" only after the Step III.

(B) We can evaluate the arguments on the basis of our experiences. Thus, in this category are the results which can be expected to follow because experiences indicate this.

Ex. Statement : Should the age of voting be raised to 21 years in India ?

Argument : Yes, by that age people develop sense of responsibility and higher level of maturity.

[Banks P.O. Exam, 2008]

Explanation : In the above mentioned example, the result that has been stipulated for the argument is probable because of our experiences. Indicate this. For example, consider that the mature age it can be assumed safety that people would take right decision.

(C) *If the result is logically probable, it will follow. In such cases we find to ascertain with proper logic whether the result will follow or not. The reasoning or logic applied in determining the validity of a result must be self-sufficient.*

Ex. Statement : Should open book examinations be introduced for professional courses in India?

Argument: Yes, all candidates can pass easily and can start their professional life. **[Banks P.O. Exam, 2009]**

Exploration : The argument mentioned above seems to be logically convincing. For example, if open book examinations be introduced in professional courses all candidates could pass the exams easily.

STEP-II

This step is meant to check whether the result is desirable or the benefits mentioned in the argument will follow beyond a reasonable doubt or the results are really harmful (in case of negative results).

Ex. Statement: Should Central Government open well equipped hospital for every sub-division of every district?

Argument: Yes, health and well-being of every Citizen is the primary responsibility of the Government.

[Bank P.O. Exam, 2009]

Explanation : Manpower is the most important resource of a country. Well being and good health of every Citizen is the prime duty of the Government. In order to ensure better health there should be sufficient number of hospitals and primary health care centres with all the facilities. Therefore, the fact stated in the argument is desirable.

STEP-III

We can reject an argument solely on the basis what the argument says seems to have no connection with the Statement. That means, an argument cannot be forceful or strong if it is not properly related with the Statement. A strong argument must be directly connected with the Statement. If its implication is connected, it cannot be a forceful argument. Thus, strong arguments are those which are both important and directly related to the statement. A strong argument should highlight the main issue involved in the statement. It should not emphasise any irrelevant, insignificant or minor issues.

Ex. Statement : Should the age of voting be raised to 21 years in India?

Argument : Yes, by that age people develop sense of responsibility and higher level of maturity.

Explanation: The argument shows proper relation with the statement and also argues important issue. Therefore, it is forceful. Through voting we elect a responsible Government and, therefore, people should have proper understanding about the right and wrong choices.

FORMAT OF THE QUESTION

Directions : In making decision about important questions, it is desirable to be able to distinguish between "Strong" arguments and "Weak" arguments so far as they relate to the question. "Strong" arguments are those which are both important and directly related to the question. "Weak" arguments are those which are of minor importance and also may not be directly related to the question or may be related to a trivial aspect of the question.

Instructions : Each question below is followed by a statement and two arguments numbered I and II. You have to decide which of the arguments is a "Strong" argument and which is a "Weak" argument.

Give **answer (1)** if only argument I is strong

Give answer (2) if only argument II is strong

Give answer (3) if either I or II is strong.

Give answer (4) if neither I nor II is strong

Give answer (5) if both I and II are strong.

ON THE BASIS of foregoing discussion we can devise systematic approach for solving questions on forcefulness of Arguments. We do suggest that you should follow the procedure given below :

A. Preliminary Screening

First of all check whether the given argument is a/an:

(i) weak argument, (ii) ambiguous argument, (iii) assumption, (iv) superfluous argument, or (v) question thrown back argument.

If an argument falls in any of the above mentioned categories, then it cannot be forceful and hence you should reject such arguments at the very beginning. If an argument does not belong to these categories, you should analyse it further step-by-step to determine its validity.

B. Step I: To test whether a result will follow or not?

A result will follow a course of action, if :

(i) it is an established fact, or (ii) experiences indicate this or (iii) it is logically probable

A result will not follow a course of action, if :

(i) it is against the established fact, or (ii) past experiences indicate so, or (iii) it is not logically probable.

If an argument conforms to Step I, move to Step II otherwise the argument is not forceful.

C. Step II: To test the desirability of the result.

If an argument can pass this Step, move to Step III otherwise the argument is not forceful.

D. Step III: To test whether the argument is properly related with the statement or not

If an argument is directly related with the statement and highlights the main issue, then it is forceful.

Above mentioned Information can be tabulated as :

Test	Argument
A. Preliminary Screening	✓
B. Step I	✓
C Step II	✓
D. Step III	✓

In this case, the argument is forceful or strong. But whenever you get a cross-mark, your task is Over. You should not waste time in analysing the argument further.

NOTE : Since preliminary Screening is somewhat exhaustive exercise and hence it cannot be equated with the subsequent steps which are not so exhaustive. That is why, we tend to categorise it separately.

E X A M P L E S

Directions (1-25): In making decisions about important questions, it is desirable to be able to distinguish between 'strong' arguments and 'weak' arguments so far as they relate to the question. 'Strong' arguments are those which are both important and directly related to the questions. 'Weak' arguments are those which are of minor importance and also may not be directly related to the questions or may be related to a trivial aspect of the question.

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This step is meant to check whether the result is desirable or the benefits mentioned in the argument will follow beyond a reasonable doubt or the results are really harmful (in case of negative results).

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Above mentioned Information can be tabulated as :

Test	Argument
A. Preliminary Screening	√
B. Step I	√
C. Step II	√
D. Step Iii	√

In this case, the argument is forceful or strong. Bul whenever you get a cross-mark, your task is over. You should not waste time in analysing the argument further.

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EXAMPLES

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Give answer (3) if either I or II is strong.

Give answer (4) if neither I nor II strong.

Give answer (5) if both I and II are strong.

Ex.1. Should all those who have come in contact with the patients suffering from the dreaded infectious respiratory disease be quarantined in their house ?

Arguments: I. No, nobody should be quarantined unless they are tested and found to be infected by the virus causing the disease.

II. Yes, this is the only way to control the spread of the dreaded disease.

Ex. 2. Should there be only one rate of interest for term deposits of varying durations in banks ?

Arguments : I. No, people will refrain from keeping money for longer duration resulting into reduction of liquidity level of banks.

II. Yes, this will be much simple for the common people and they may be encouraged to keep more money in banks.

Ex.3. Should there be a cap on maximum number of contestants for parliamentary elections in any constituency?

Arguments : I. Yes, this will make the parliamentary elections more meaningful as the voters can make a considered judgement for casting their vote.

II. No, in a democracy any person fulfilling the eligibility criteria can contest parliamentary elections and there should be no such restrictions.

Ex.4. Should all those who are found guilty of committing homicide or abetting homicide be either given capital punishment or be kept in jail for the entire life ?

Arguments : I. Yes, such severe punishments only will make people refrain from committing such heinous acts and the society will be more safe.

II. No, those who are repentant for the crime they committed be given a chance to lead a normal life outside the jail.

Ex.5. Should there be a restriction on the migration of people from one **State** to another State in India ?

Arguments : I. No, any Indian **Citizen** has a basic right to stay at any place of their choice and hence they cannot be stopped.

II. Yes, this is the way to effect an equitable distribution of resources across the States in India.

Ex.6. Should powerful nations attack relatively weaker nations which pose probable danger to world peace ?

Arguments: I. Yes. War is justified for the noble purpose of peace keeping.

II. No. War/violence should never be resorted to.

Ex. 7. Should those people who get less than Rs. 10 lakh per annum be exempted from the income tax ?

Argument: I. Yes. Employees can improve their Standard of living by this.

II. No. They should not be debarred from serving the country.

Ex. 8. Should there be ban on free movement of people affected by contagious diseases like SARS ?

Arguments : I. Yes. This is the way which will benefit such patients.

II. No. This will cause further deterioration **in** their health.

Ex.9. Should all slum dwellers of metros in India be forcibly sent to their villages ?

Arguments: I. No. Because these people will die of hunger as there are no employment opportunities in villages.

II. Yes. Slums create a bad impression of our country in the eyes of the foreign tourists.

Ex. 10. Should public sector units of our country **discard** the policy of making available economic package to eligible poor gradually ?

Arguments : I. Yes. It is difficult to define "eligible **poors**".

II. No. It is against the welfare policy adopted by India.

Ex. 11. Should there be a compulsory military training for each **College Student** in India ?

Arguments: I. No. Compulsion always leads to repulsion.

II. Yes. This is the only way to impart discipline **into** young generation.

Ex. 12. Should the vehicles older than 15 years be rejected in metros in India ?

Arguments : I. This is a significant step to lower down the pollution level in metros.

II. No. It will be very difficult for vehicle owners to shift to other parts in country because they will not get suitable job for their very existence.

Ex. 13. Should all the Colleges in India be allowed to devise their own curriculum and syllabus for the vocational courses promoting self-employment ?

Arguments: I. Yes. This is an important step to generate employment opportunities.

II. No. This will affect the quality of education due to lack of uniformity in syllabus.

Ex. 14. Should the educated un-employed youth be **paid** "unemployment allowance" by the Government ?

Arguments : I. No. It will dampen their urge to **do** something to earn their livelihood.

II. Yes. It will provide them some monetary help to either seek employment or to kickstart some 'self employment' venture.

Ex. 15. Should private **Courier** Services in our country be legally banned ?

Arguments : I. Yes. They have adversely affected the postal department.

II. No. They have been found to be very fast **and** reliable.

Ex. 16. Should all beggars on the roads in the big cities in India be forcibly sent to villages ?

Arguments: I. No, this is grossly unfair and these people will die of hunger if they are sent to villages.

II. Yes, these people create a bad impression of our country in the eyes of the foreigners who visit our country and hence should be removed.

Ex. 17. Should all the criminals convicted for committing murder be awarded capital punishment ?

Arguments : I. Yes, this will be a significant step towards reducing cases of murder in future.

II. No, nobody has the right to take any person's life irrespective of the acts of such individuals.

Ex. 18. Should all the professional Colleges in India be encouraged to run their own courses without affiliation to any university ?

Arguments : I. Yes, this is only way to create more opportunities for those who seek professional training.

II. No, this will dilute the quality of professional training as all such Colleges may not be equipped to conduct such courses.

Ex. 19. Should there be a maximum ceiling imposed on the earnings of an individual in an Organisation ?

Arguments : I. Yes, this will help equitable distribution of earnings to all the employees.

II. No, the Organisation should have free hand to decide the pay packets of its employees.

Ex. 20. Should there be a compulsory military training for each College Student in India ?

Arguments : I. No» this goes against the basic democratic right of an individual to choose his/her own programs.

II. Yes, this is the only way to build a strong and powerful nation.

Ex. 21. Should all those passed out from government run Colleges and desirous of settling abroad be asked to pay back the cost of their education to the government ?

Arguments : I. Yes, such students who study on the resources of the exchequer should be discouraged to leave the country.

II. No, every Citizen has right to select their place of further study or work and therefore such a condition is unjustified.

Ex. 22. Should India support all the international policies of United States of America ?

Arguments : I. No, many other powerful countries do not support the same.

II. Yes, this is the only way to gain access to USA developmental funds.

Ex. 23. Should there be a complete ban on use of pesticides in agricultural sector ?

Arguments : I. Yes, this is the only way to save the Underground water from getting polluted with such dangerous chemical.

II. No, this will adversely affect the agricultural production and the pests will damage the crops.

Ex. 24. Should the labour reforms be immediately introduced in India?

Arguments: I. Yes, this will help increase the productivity in all the sectors in general and in the public sector in particular.

II. No, many other countries have not implemented this so far.

Ex. 25. Should the subsidy on kerosene be immediately increased further ?

Arguments : I. Yes, this will bring considerable relief to the poorer section of the society as they will be the major beneficiary.

II. No, our economy is otherwise in a difficult stage and it will not be able to withstand any further burden on it.

EXPLANATIONS

1.(1) Only argument I seems to be strong. The use of term 'only' in the argument II makes it invalid. Any disease can be checked by detecting causative organism and treating it properly. If the disease is contagious, the people suffering from the disease should be provided with suitable treatment.

2.(1) Only argument I seems to be strong. If the rate of interest for term deposits of varying durations in banks be

kept uniform, no people will keep their money for long duration. Argument II is not desirable and hence it is not strong.

3.(5) Both the arguments seem to be strong. Ineffective candidates should be discouraged to contest elections for sustaining vibrant democracy. On the other hand, it is a democratic right to contest elections and as such no person can be debarred from contesting elections if he is eligible otherwise.

4.(1) Only argument I seems to be strong. The provision of severe punishments may have some effects and people will refrain from committing such heinous acts as homicide. Considering the severity of crimes such persons should be punished necessarily.

5.(1) Only argument I seems to be strong. Argument I is in accordance with the fundamental rights guaranteed to the Citizens by the Constitution of India. How this step will ensure equitable distribution of resources ? This question remains unanswered. Therefore, argument II is not strong.

6.(4) Neither of the arguments seems to be strong. War should be avoided at any cost as it aggravates the Situation rather than solving any problem. However, sometimes war becomes inevitable to ensure peace and security environment.

7.(4) Neither of the arguments seems to be strong. Both the arguments are devoid of facts.

8.(4) Both the arguments lack substance and hence cannot be strong.

9.(4) Neither of the arguments seems to be strong.

10.(2) Only argument II seems to be strong. The Constitution of India envisages the policy of welfare State and therefore, weaker sections of society should be given certain concessions.

11.(1) Only argument I seems to be strong. The use of term 'only' in the argument II makes it invalid.

12.(1) Only argument I seems to be strong. Pollution is a great menace to the society and its environment.

13.(1) Only argument I seems to be strong. Uniformity in syllabus can be maintained by adopting suitable measures.

14.(2) Only argument II is strong.

15.(4) Neither of the arguments seems to be strong.

16.(1) The problem of beggars cannot be solved by sending them to villages. Therefore, argument I seems to be strong.

17.(1) Murder is a heinous crime and it should be discouraged earnestly. Severity of punishment may bring some desirable results.

18.(4) Neither of the arguments seems to be strong. The use of term 'only' in the argument I makes it invalid.

19.(4) Neither of the arguments seems to be strong.

20.(1) Only argument I is strong. The use of term 'only' in the argument II makes it invalid.

21.(1) Only argument I seems to be strong. The problem of brain-drain can be solved to some extent by this measure.

22.(4) Argument I is based on a precedent or an example. We know that citing example or describing precedent is bad argumentation.

23.(2) Only argument II seems to be strong. The use of term 'only' in the argument I makes it invalid.

24.(1) Only argument I seems to be strong. Labour certainly affects productivity. Argument II is based on an example and hence it may not be strong.

25.(2) Only argument II seems to be strong.